



General Assembly

Distr.: General
24 August 2026

Original: English

Eightieth session

Agenda item 13

**Integrated and coordinated implementation of and follow-up
to the outcomes of the major United Nations conferences and
summits in the economic, social and related fields**

Unique challenges faced by developing countries in artificial intelligence capacity-building

Report of the Secretary-General*

Summary

The present report is submitted pursuant to General Assembly resolution [78/311](#), in which the Assembly requested the Secretary-General to report to it at its eightieth session on the unique challenges faced by developing countries in artificial intelligence capacity-building, with recommendations that address those challenges.

* The present report was submitted to the conference services for processing after the deadline for technical reasons beyond the control of the submitting office.



I. Introduction

1. There is a pressing need to ensure a universal floor of artificial intelligence (AI) capacity in all countries while working to narrow the AI divide. Doing so is critical to achieving the ambitions of the Global Digital Compact and accelerating progress towards implementing the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development in a way that leaves no country behind. This report builds on previous analysis and findings, including those set out in the 2024 report of the High-level Advisory Body on Artificial Intelligence¹ and the 2025 report of the Secretary-General on innovative voluntary financing options for artificial intelligence capacity-building (A/79/966), which presented financing options to address underlying AI capacity needs and gaps as a common challenge faced by developing countries. This challenge persists in 2026 and warrants global action, as recommended in this report.

II. Unique challenges faced by developing countries in artificial intelligence capacity-building

2. While all countries must contend with fast-moving AI technologies, many developing countries face additional unique challenges in AI capacity-building. One is that their initial AI capacities tend to be limited. This includes gaps in foundational AI capacity, such as with regard to computing, associated energy and connectivity supply and high-quality data; in digital public infrastructure, such as model use case repositories; and in skills for AI development and deployment.² It also includes gaps in enabler AI capacity, such as with regard to relevant legislative, regulatory and governance frameworks with appropriate accountability and redress mechanisms (including in relation to human, gender and labour rights); in institutional public service capacity to assess, procure, deploy, apply and govern AI effectively;³ and in the capacity to participate in international AI governance processes. These gaps hinder the development of both domestic AI industry and public sector capacity to adopt, assess and govern AI solutions.

3. Most developing countries also face constraints which hinder growth in AI capacities that support national development priorities. These can include data scarcity in languages with limited digital representation, nascent digital economies with limited digital infrastructure and talent brain drains across public and private sectors. Such constraints can combine to make the risk-adjusted rates of return on capital too low to attract adequate private investment or loans for local AI capacity, while limiting developing countries' bargaining power vis-à-vis technology providers. These constraints can also reinforce existing inequalities within countries, limiting who is able to access and benefit from AI. For developing countries that can

¹ *Governing AI for Humanity: Final Report* (United Nations publication, 2024).

² For example, while high-income countries accounted for 77 per cent of global co-location data centre capacity in June 2025, lower-middle-income countries accounted for 5 per cent, and low-income countries for less than 0.1 per cent. Two thirds of people in high-income countries had basic digital skills in 2023, compared to 21 per cent in lower-middle-income countries, and less than 5 percent in low-income countries in 2023. World Bank Group, *Digital Progress and Trends Report 2025: Strengthening AI Foundations* (Washington, D.C., 2025), pp. xiv and xv.

³ While around half of all Member States had a national AI strategy in place in 2025, less than 20 per cent of the least developed countries did so. Analysis of data from the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University for its *Artificial Intelligence Index Report* (accessed July 2026).

be characterized as being in the lower tiers of AI maturity,⁴ a lack of adequate financing is a unique challenge limiting AI capacity-building for local development, resulting in less-informed choices, passive technological consumption and a widening divide.

4. The window for concerted action to harness the benefits of AI while addressing its risks is rapidly closing.⁵ The central challenge is to develop a minimum level of AI capacity in all countries, thus strengthening agency to promote the welfare of their peoples and respect for their fundamental human rights, including the rights to privacy and to a clean, healthy and sustainable environment, and to reduce dependency. To understand the technology, its implications, how to govern it and how to develop, deploy and use it responsibly, including as an enabling layer for other technologies, countries require a minimum level of AI capacity across all its dimensions, tailored to national contexts. Such direct technical exposure is necessary for countries to experience, experiment with and harness AI technologies through real-world applications in their own local contexts, thereby developing a clear understanding of the opportunities, risks and governance steps to be taken. Member States also require public sector institutional capacity, including at the subnational levels, to govern and use AI technologies and foster local ecosystems aligned with national priorities⁶ and to provide an evidence base to support policymaking through a whole-of-government approach.⁷

5. The United Nations system has been scaling up its response, including through the implementation of General Assembly resolution 79/325,⁸ as well as through the conduct of AI readiness assessments and the establishment of partnerships to provide guidance and support to Member States in different areas. Examples include efforts made across the International Telecommunication Union, the United Nations Development Programme, the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization, the United Nations Population Fund, the United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat), the United Nations Children's Fund, the United Nations Industrial Development Organization and the United Nations Secretariat (the Department of Economic and Social Affairs, the Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, the Office for Disarmament Affairs and the regional economic commissions).⁹ These efforts, alongside the work of industry, civil society and academia, amount to several millions of dollars in programming. However, they are insufficient to cover all countries at the necessary scale to keep pace with technological change.

⁴ In his 2025 report (A/79/966), the Secretary-General makes the case that capacity-building efforts and their financing should be tailored to countries' differing levels of AI maturity and introduces five tiers of AI maturity, corresponding to differing AI capacities (see box I).

⁵ *Preliminary Report of the Independent International Scientific Panel on AI: Evidence-based Assessment of Opportunities, Risks and Impacts of Artificial Intelligence* (United Nations publication, 2026), p. 28.

⁶ *Human Development Report 2025: A Matter of Choice – People and Possibilities in the Age of AI* (United Nations publication, 2025), pp. 185 and 186.

⁷ *Technology and Innovation Report 2025: Inclusive Artificial Intelligence for Development* (United Nations publication, 2025), p. 158.

⁸ General Assembly resolution 79/325 contains the terms of reference and modalities for the establishment and functioning of the Independent International Scientific Panel on Artificial Intelligence and the Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance. In the resolution, the Assembly stressed that the work of the Panel and the Dialogue would contribute to informing and improving capacity-building efforts on artificial intelligence.

⁹ For a full compilation of current United Nations system activities on AI capacity-building, see the online reference document available at www.un.org/sites/un2.un.org/files/b_online_reference_document_un_system_aicb_activities.pdf.

6. Current financing for AI capacity-building is fragmented and leaves significant geographical gaps.¹⁰ At a time when private investment in AI infrastructure exceeds half a trillion United States dollars, annualized,¹¹ a needs-based global fund for AI capacity-building, with the active involvement of all stakeholders and initial funding commitments in the range of \$3 billion over two to four years,¹² could help mobilize and direct resources at scale to enable countries that do not yet have the material AI capacity to move to tier 1 or tier 2. This would represent a crucial achievement in enabling all countries to leverage AI to accelerate inclusive and equitable sustainable development. In this regard, a thorough mapping of a country's AI needs and capacities vis-à-vis its development priorities and sustainable development challenges will be essential, to ensure that all countries, regardless of their development trajectory, can benefit from AI to address their unique challenges. Such a fund should complement existing United Nations and in-kind contribution mechanisms and international partnerships, mobilizing additional resources and scaling up existing efforts while advancing nationally owned strategies and measurable development outcomes. It could be within or outside the United Nations system. Potential models for such a fund could include the independent Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria, the Global Financing Facility for Women, Children and Adolescents and some of those analysed for the 2025 report.¹³

III. Recommendations

7. **The Secretary-General recommends that the General Assembly endorse the need for and take steps to advance the establishment of a global fund for AI capacity-building, including by elaborating its strategic objectives and modalities for its governance and administration at the eighty-first session of the General Assembly, informed by the recommendations of the High-level Advisory Body on Artificial Intelligence, his 2025 report (A/79/966) and a forthcoming discussion paper on the governance and operating model of such a fund, based, inter alia, on consultations with potential donors, stakeholders and the United Nations system convened by the Secretary-General.**

8. **The General Assembly may wish to request the Secretary-General to report regularly on the state of AI capacity across countries, supported by measurable indicators of progress, including against national AI strategies and drawing on existing methodologies within the United Nations system, until appropriate regular reporting arrangements on AI capacity needs are agreed.**

9. **Member States are encouraged to nominate additional centres to join the United Nations-supported Global Network of Centres for Exchange and Cooperation on AI Capacity Building.**

¹⁰ See the online reference document on the analysis of AI capacity-building financing announcements, available at www.un.org/sites/un2.un.org/files/a_online_reference_document_financing_announcements.pdf.

¹¹ *Preliminary Report of the Independent International Scientific Panel on AI*, p. 28.

¹² A/79/966, para. 40; and *Governing AI for Humanity*, p. 46.

¹³ See the online reference document for the 2025 report (A/79/966) on case studies of existing innovative financing mechanisms and how they could be adapted for AI capacity-building in lower-middle-income countries, available at www.un.org/sites/un2.un.org/files/z5jekq.pdf.